



It is thought that Cahokia went into a gradual decline beginning around 1200, and was completely abandoned by 1400. The inhabitants left no written records, and the city's original name is unknown—"Cahokia" refers to a nearby Illiniwek clan that was present in the area when French settlers arrived in the 17th century.



Monks Mound, Cahokia
Large Mississippian settlements were dominated by massive pyramidal mounds of earth that served as bases for temples—where the people could observe celestial events such as the summer and winter solstices—or the residences of the more powerful individuals.

The Mississippians were accomplished craftsmen, and archaeological excavations have revealed a range of ceramic vessels, some of them sculpted to look like trophy heads taken in warfare. Intricately carved pipes and ceremonial axes have also been found. Excavations carried out at the Spiro Mound have produced shell gorgets (decorative disks worn around the neck) with representations of warriors and snakes.

AFTER

The arrival of the Spanish conquistadors (conquerors) had far-reaching effects on the peoples of Mesoamerica and much of South America, devastating traditions and ways of life that had existed for hundreds of years.

THE CONQUISTADORS

Arriving in Mexico in 1519, **Hernán Cortés 230–31** >> heard about the wealthy Aztec city Tenochtitlán. With a group of Spanish soldiers and some local enemies of the Aztecs, he took control of the city in 1521. Most of the city was destroyed, but it was rebuilt by the Spanish as Mexico City, capital of the Viceroyalty of New Spain.

The **Spanish** reached the **Yucatán** in about 1524. Although individual independent centers did fall to the conquistadors, the Maya often put up a fierce fight. The last stronghold submitted in 1697.

In 1532, **Francisco Pizarro 231** >> obtained permission from Spain to overcome the Inca, who had already been weakened by a civil war and smallpox. They finally fell to the Spanish in 1572.

THE FATE OF THE MISSISSIPPIANS

The decline of the Mississippian culture began before the arrival of the Spanish and French as a result of intertribal warfare and malnutrition, compounded by the spread of European diseases.